SAMUI LUXURY STAYS

RELOCATION SERVICES

VILLA MANAGEMENT · SALES · RELOCATION

MOVING TO KOH SAMUI

The complete guide to finding a safe home on the island

WHAT'S INSIDE

Where to live · What it costs · Renting step by step

How to avoid rental scams · Paperwork & practicalities

Moving with children · Your moving timeline

A FREE GUIDE FROM

Samui Luxury Stays

Rooster Island Holdings Co. · 2026 Edition

Welcome to the island

Every year, people from all over the world decide to make Koh Samui home. Some come for a year of remote work, some to retire, and some to give their children a different kind of childhood. Most settle in happily, and the ones who do it most smoothly are those who plan the practical details before they arrive.

This guide pulls those details together in one place: where to live, what to budget for, how to rent safely, how to avoid the scams that catch newcomers out, and what to do before and after you land. It is written by a team that lives and works on the island.

> **HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE**
>
> Read it start to finish once, then use the checklists and the budget worksheet as you plan. Each section stands on its own, so you can jump straight to the part you need.

CONTENTS

1	Is Koh Samui right for you?
2	Where to live: area by area
3	Planning your budget
4	Finding and renting a home, step by step
5	Avoiding rental scams
6	Paperwork and practicalities
7	Moving with children: schools and family life
8	Your moving timeline
9	How we can help

> **A NOTE ON ACCURACY**
>
> This guide is general information, not legal, tax, medical or immigration advice. Rules, costs and conditions change, so please confirm current requirements before you travel.

1 Is Koh Samui right for you?

Koh Samui is a well-loved island with beaches, mountains, good restaurants and a settled international community. It is also a small island in a tropical climate, with a pace and a set of frictions that surprise some newcomers. Being honest with yourself about both sides is the best start.

WHAT PEOPLE LOVE

- The climate, the sea and the outdoor lifestyle
- A friendly, international community
- Good food and an easy daily rhythm
- Lower living costs than many Western countries, with real variation
- Space and nature within a few minutes of town

WHAT TO PLAN FOR

- Slower bureaucracy and paperwork
- A distinct wet season, typically October to December
- Most areas are not walkable, so you need transport
- Imported goods cost more
- Building a real local network takes time

> **OUR ADVICE: RENT FIRST**
>
> Almost everyone who thrives here rented for a meaningful period before buying anything. Your area, your type of home and even the decision to stay long-term all become clearer after you have lived on the island. Even a short scouting trip, outside the peak tourist weeks, tells you more than months of research.

A QUICK SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I know roughly how long I plan to stay
- ☐ I know my monthly budget, including surprises
- ☐ I have thought about healthcare and insurance
- ☐ I have a plan for visas, with a qualified adviser
- ☐ I know what matters most in a home: location, space, pool, internet, quiet
- ☐ I understand that I should never pay for a home I have not seen

2 Where to live: area by area

Koh Samui is small enough to drive around in a few hours, yet its neighbourhoods feel very different. Choose your area by how you will live, not by which beach looks best in photos.

AREA	WHERE	THE FEEL
Bophut & Fisherman's Village	North coast	Lively walking street, restaurants, boutiques and a large expat community; handy for the airport.
Bang Rak	North-east	Home of the Big Buddha; close to the airport, with shops, cafes and a calm, local feel.
Plai Laem	North-east	Between Bang Rak and Choeng Mon, near the Guanyin temple and lake; central, well served, popular with long-stay residents.
Choeng Mon	North-east	Calm, upmarket bay with soft sand, cafes and luxury villas; quiet, with the airport close by.
Chaweng Noi	East coast	A smaller, quieter bay just north of Chaweng, with hillside homes and sea views.
Chaweng	East coast	The island's busiest beach: the most shops, restaurants, nightlife and services.
Lamai	South-east	A wide beach and a lively town centre; a mix of budget homes and luxury villas.
Maenam & Ban Tai	North coast	Long, quieter beach with an evening market and a relaxed pace; good value, popular with families and long-term residents.
Nathon	West coast	The island's main town and ferry port, with the hospital, government offices and lower prices; not a beach resort.
Lipa Noi	West coast	Peaceful, green and local, with calm water, sunsets and a mix of villas and affordable homes.
Taling Ngam	South-west	Remote, tranquil hillside villas with sunset views; away from the airport and nightlife.
Na Muang	South coast	Inland-feeling south of the island near the waterfalls; green, quiet and good value.

Families

Most look to the north and north-east, where schools, clinics and supermarkets are close: Maenam, Bophut, Choeng Mon.

Remote workers

Reliable fibre internet matters more than the beach. Test the speed at the address. Bophut, Chaweng and the north are well served.

Quiet seekers

Choeng Mon, Maenam, Lipa Noi and Taling Ngam offer calm and sunsets, but check distance to healthcare and shops.

Area notes are a general guide only and conditions change. Tell us your priorities and we will match you to the right neighbourhoods.

3 Planning your budget

Living on Koh Samui can cost much less or about as much as home. It depends far more on how you choose to live than on the island itself. Instead of relying on a single headline number, build your own budget from the lines below.

WHAT DRIVES YOUR COSTS

- **Rent:** the largest and most variable cost. It varies by area, size, standard, furnishing, pool and view. Shorter leases cost more per month than 6 to 12-month leases
- **Electricity:** air-conditioning is usually the biggest bill. Ask for recent bills, and whether the landlord charges utility rates or adds a mark-up
- **Water, internet and mobile:** usually modest, but confirm fibre at the address
- **Pool and garden care:** check who pays
- **Food:** local markets are affordable, while imported groceries carry a premium
- **Transport:** most people need a car or scooter, plus fuel, insurance and servicing
- **Healthcare and insurance:** private care is good but not cheap
- **Schooling:** a major cost for families
- **One-off setup:** deposit, first month's rent, furniture and kitchen items if unfurnished

YOUR BUDGET WORKSHEET

COST	WHAT TO ASK OR CHECK	MY MONTHLY ESTIMATE
Rent	Lease length, furnished or not, what is included	
Electricity	Last 3 bills; air-conditioning use; rate per unit	
Water and internet	Fibre available at the address? Speed test	
Pool and garden	Who pays and who arranges it	
Food and eating out	Mix of local and imported	
Transport	Fuel, insurance, servicing	
Health insurance	Covers treatment in Thailand?	
Schooling	Current fees confirmed with the school	
Other	Visas, phone, leisure, travel home	
Safety margin	Add 10 to 15% for the unexpected	

4 Finding and renting a home, step by step

- **Start early.** Begin two to three months before you arrive and stay flexible on dates by a few weeks
- **Write your non-negotiables.** Budget, bedrooms, commute, internet, pets, parking, beach or hillside
- **Choose your area** using section 2
- **See homes in person, or have someone you trust do it.** Photos flatter; they do not show noise, flooding, damp or real internet speed
- **Check the landlord.** Confirm identity and right to let before you pay anything
- **Read the lease** and agree every term in writing
- **Pay safely:** only against a signed lease and a written receipt
- **Arrange utilities and move-in** before your arrival day

VIEWING CHECKLIST

- ☐ Air-conditioning works well
- ☐ Plumbing and hot water
- ☐ Electrics and sockets
- ☐ Damp, mould or roof leaks
- ☐ Internet speed and mobile signal
- ☐ Pool and garden condition
- ☐ Noise, neighbours and road access
- ☐ Flood and drainage risk
- ☐ Safe parking
- ☐ Furniture and appliances match the list

LEASE CHECKLIST

- ☐ Correct names of landlord and tenant
- ☐ Correct property and address
- ☐ Monthly rent and payment method
- ☐ Security deposit amount and return terms
- ☐ Length of lease and renewal terms
- ☐ Notice period for both sides
- ☐ Early-termination terms
- ☐ Who pays repairs, pool and garden care
- ☐ Who pays electricity, water and internet
- ☐ Rent-increase rules
- ☐ An inventory of furniture and appliances
- ☐ A signed copy for you

TYPICAL ARRANGEMENTS

Leases commonly run 6 to 12 months, and shorter rentals usually cost more per month. A refundable security deposit plus the first month in advance is a common arrangement, but terms vary, so always ask.

5 Avoiding rental scams

Fake owners and fake agents are a well-known problem on Koh Samui, and many newcomers have lost deposits to them. People searching from overseas are the easiest targets. The scams follow a few patterns, and once you know them they are easy to spot.

THE COMMON PATTERNS

- **The listing that does not exist:** copied photos and a low price. You are asked to pay a deposit to hold it, and the home is not available
- **The owner who is always abroad:** cannot meet or do a video call, but an 'agent' will handle things once you send money
- **The agent who is not an agent:** shows a real property, takes a fee, and has no authority to let it
- **The double let:** the same villa is rented to several people at once, or sublet without the owner's permission
- **The fake proof of payment:** a screenshot saying someone else has paid, to push you to pay quickly

RED FLAGS

- Pressure to pay before you have seen the property
- Refusal of a live video walkthrough
- A price far below similar homes
- Photos you can find elsewhere online
- Payment to a personal account or by crypto
- An account name that does not match the owner
- No written lease
- A story that keeps changing

HOW TO VERIFY

- See it in person or on a live video
- Ask for proof of the right to let, such as the title deed or written authority from the owner
- Check the landlord's ID
- Search the photos online
- Ask neighbours and local managers
- Read the lease before paying

> **SAFE PAYMENT RULES**
>
> Never pay for a place you have not seen. Pay only against a signed lease and a written receipt. Make sure the account name matches the owner or a registered company. Keep records of every message and payment.

> **IF YOU THINK YOU HAVE BEEN SCAMMED**
>
> Contact your bank straight away, keep every message and receipt, and report it to the local police or the Tourist Police on 1155. Recovery is never guaranteed, which is why prevention matters most.

6 Paperwork and practicalities

Immigration and paperwork

Landlords normally report foreign tenants to Thai immigration (TM30), so ask yours.

Keep copies of your passport, visa and lease together.

Visas and work permits change; take advice from a licensed immigration adviser.

Getting around

Most areas are not walkable: plan for a car or scooter.

An International Driving Permit is generally needed to drive legally.

Taxis and ride-hailing exist but are costly for daily use.

Seasons and weather

Hot and dry from roughly February to August.

The wetter months typically run from about October to December.

Check roof, drainage and access roads before you sign.

Healthcare

Private hospitals and clinics offer English-speaking care.

Make sure your insurance covers treatment in Thailand.

Register with a clinic early.

Utilities and internet

Ask whether electricity and water are at utility rates.

Confirm fibre internet at the address.

Have a backup mobile connection if you work remotely.

Daily life

Supermarkets, gyms and schools cluster in the north and east.

Local markets are the best value for food.

Join local groups to build your network.

ASK A PROFESSIONAL

Visas, taxes, banking and the legal side of renting or buying are specialist areas. Use a licensed adviser or lawyer rather than forums, and confirm current rules before you travel.

7 Moving with children: schools and family life

Many families find Koh Samui a wonderful place to grow up. Plan around schools, healthcare and safety first, then choose an area and a home to suit family life. The island has British-style international schools, a bilingual Thai-English school and a French school.

SCHOOL	AREA	CURRICULUM & AGES
International School of Samui	North-east, between Bophut and Chaweng	British, with Cambridge IGCSE and A-Levels. Ages 3 to 18.
PanyaDee, The British International School of Samui	Bophut area	Cambridge and IGCSE, in English. Nursery to Year 13.
Oonrak Koh Samui School (bilingual)	Maenam area	Thai curriculum with British and Cambridge content; about half the lessons in each language. Pre-K to Primary 6.
Lamai International School	Lamai / Maret	British and Cambridge. Foundation to Year 6.
Windfield International School	Lamai / Maret	British and French curricula, multilingual.
Greenacre International School	South (Na Muang)	British EYFS and IGCSE, in English. Ages 3 to 16.
IFDS – École Française de Koh Samui	Chaweng	French national curriculum. Preschool to final year.
Samui Centre of Learning	Chaweng	British, with IGCSE and A-Level courses.

School details change, and directories do not always agree on locations, curricula or fees. Please confirm current details, availability and fees directly with each school before you decide.

CHOOSING A FAMILY HOME

- **Pools:** a private pool needs a fence or cover and constant supervision with small children
- **Stairs and balconies:** villas often have several levels; check them with children in mind
- **Air-conditioning in the bedrooms**, mosquito screens and pest control
- **Distance** to a clinic and to the nearest shops and school

8 Your moving timeline

3 MONTHS BEFORE

- ☐ Decide your budget and your must-haves
- ☐ Research areas and schools
- ☐ Speak to a licensed immigration adviser
- ☐ Check your health insurance
- ☐ Start your home search

6 WEEKS BEFORE

- ☐ Shortlist homes; view in person or by a trusted person
- ☐ Verify each landlord
- ☐ Agree lease terms in writing
- ☐ Arrange to pay only against a signed lease

2 WEEKS BEFORE

- ☐ Confirm the move-in date and keys
- ☐ Arrange utilities and internet
- ☐ Book flights and arrival transport
- ☐ Plan transport: car, scooter, driving permit

ARRIVAL WEEK

- ☐ Collect keys and check the inventory
- ☐ Photograph the condition of the home
- ☐ Test air-conditioning, hot water, internet
- ☐ Note meter readings
- ☐ Register with a local clinic
- ☐ Confirm the landlord has reported you (TM30)

FIRST MONTH

- ☐ Set up local mobile, banking and payments
- ☐ Explore your area and find your supermarket
- ☐ Meet neighbours and local groups
- ☐ Review your budget against real costs
- ☐ Tell us how it is going

> **DON'T FORGET**
>
> Keep copies of your passport, visa, lease, insurance and school records together, on paper and digitally.

9 How we can help

Moving to the island but not here yet? Our team lives on Koh Samui. We view, vet and shortlist rental properties on your behalf, so you arrive to a trusted short list of homes, not a hotel room and a browser tab. We also help with villa sales, long-term rentals and villa management.

RELOCATION PROPERTY SEARCH

Scout

฿12,000 one-off

- Up to 6 matched properties
- Photos, pricing and lease terms
- Area and neighbourhood notes
- Delivered within 5 working days

Shortlist

฿28,000 one-off

- Everything in Scout
- In-person inspection of every property
- Walkthrough video for each home
- Landlord and agent background checks
- One follow-up round of searching

Full Relocation

฿55,000 one-off

- Everything in Shortlist
- Lease negotiation on your behalf
- Contract and deposit review
- Airport pickup on arrival day
- Accompanied final viewings · Utilities and move-in coordination

IMPORTANT TERMS

Fees are non-refundable. Package fees cover our time and local expertise, not the properties themselves: you deal directly with landlords for rent and deposits.

Availability is not guaranteed. Villas can be rented to others between our search and your arrival. A property is only secured once a holding deposit has been paid to the landlord.

Prices are in Thai Baht; we can quote in your home currency on request.

HOW TO START

Go to **www.samuiluxurystays.com/relocation.html** and send us your brief: your arrival date, budget and must-haves. We will confirm the right package and begin searching straight away.

Samui Luxury Stays · Rooster Island Holdings Co. · Bophut, Koh Samui, Surat Thani, Thailand